A Real-World SOC 2 Report Example Explained [+ Free PDF Download]

Seeing a real example of how a SOC 2 report might look can be incredibly useful when preparing for an audit.

Here's a sample SOC 2 report from ABC Company, an equity management solutions platform.

What is a SOC 2 Report?

A SOC 2 report provides detailed results of a SOC 2 audit. They also contain a wealth of information about your company's security posture, specifically as it relates to the security standards covered by SOC 2.

SOC reporting and standards

Understanding the core concepts of SOC 2 can help you better understand the report structure.

Developed by the American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (AICPA), SOC 2 reports are meant specifically for audits related to security and privacy controls.

SOC reports are also categorized as either Type I or Type II, depending on whether the SOC audit took place at a single point in time (Type I) or on an ongoing basis (Type II).

Controls covered by SOC

“Controls” refer to policies, procedures, or processes used to mitigate risk.

A security control, for example, could be using multi-factor authentication to prevent unauthorized logins. SOC reports use the Trust Services Criteria:

1. **Security:** Firewalls, multi-factor authentication, etc.
2. **Availability:** Disaster recovery, performance monitoring, etc.
3. **Confidentiality:** Access control, encryption, etc.
4. **Processing integrity:** Process monitoring, quality control, etc.
5. **Privacy:** Encryption, access control, etc.

A SOC 2 report evaluates how well a service organization has implemented these security controls.

SOC 2 Report Structure

The main goal of SOC 2 reporting is to discuss whether a particular system meets the audit criteria. A SOC 2 report must provide detailed information about the audit itself, the system, and the perspectives of management.

SOC 2 reports include:

- Report from the auditor
- Management assertion
- System description
- Tests of controls
- Other information

1. Report from the auditor

The first section of a SOC 2 report is a summary of the audit provided by the auditor. Short, sweet, and to the point, this section should provide a brief summary of the entire SOC examination, including the scope, period, and the auditor's opinion.

For many, the most important part of this section is the auditor’s opinion, which says whether the service organization is in compliance with SOC 2 requirements. Here, auditors sometimes use special terms to describe the results.

They are:

- Unqualified: The company passed its audit.
- Qualified: The company passed, but some areas require attention.
- Adverse: The company failed its audit.
- Disclaimer of Opinion: The auditor doesn't have enough information to make a fair conclusion.

2. Management assertion

The management assertion allows the company to make claims about the audited systems and controls.

Most management assertions are simply the company's way of saying, "these are our systems, these are their controls, and this is what we think about it right now." This section may also include the company's assertions about the audit itself, such as the audit window and scope.

This section might seem somewhat redundant, but it's often necessary for creating a legal basis between the company and the auditor.

3. System description

While the management assertion might provide a brief system description, this section goes into more detail. It covers everything from system components to procedures to system incidents.

Common parts of a system description include:

- System scope and requirements
- System components (e.g., infrastructure, people, etc.)
- Control frameworks
- System incidents
- Complementary information (e.g., user responsibilities, etc.)

Of course, this section is only as detailed and complex as the system itself. A simple system may only need a simple description, and vise-versa.

4. Tests of controls

Easily the longest part of any SOC 2 report, this section is a complete collection of every test performed during the audit.

Most SOC 2 reports show tests in a table format with the following information:

- Criteria (CC)
- Trust services category or control objectives
- Control number
- Control description from the company
- Test description from the auditor
- Test results

Unlike other sections, you only need to read the tests that are relevant to the controls you're interested in. In other words, think of this section as an encyclopedia rather than a novel.

5. Other information

Some SOC 2 reports may include an extra section for additional information or management's response to specific test results. In the example below, ABC Company used this section to provide feedback for tests where auditors noted exceptions.

SOC 2 Report Example

As a fintech company, ABC Company's business relies on keeping its customer data secure. Their SOC 2 report, outlined below, shows how they do that through the standard set by the AICPAs Trust Services Criteria.

While many SOC 2 reports have over 100 pages of documentation, we'll focus on highlighting some of the most actionable areas.

Section I: Report from the auditor

Of all the pages in this report, this section is the most read. The company's auditor provides a detailed audit summary, beginning with an outline of the purpose and a brief system description.

Here's a snippet of the SOC 2 system description example:

ABC Company

Section III

Scope and Boundaries of the System

This is a System and Organization Controls ("SOC") 2 Type 2 report and includes a description of ABC Company's (the Company) platform system (the Platform) and the controls in place to provide reasonable assurance that ABC Company's service commitments and system requirements were achieved based on the Trust Services Criteria relevant to the security criteria set forth in TSP section 100, (2017) Trust Services Criteria for Security, Availability, Processing Integrity, Confidentiality, and Privacy ("AICPA, Technical Practice Aids") ("applicable trust services criteria"), throughout the period January 1, 2021 to December 31, 2021, which may be relevant to users of the ABC Company Platform. It does not encompass all aspects of the services provided or procedures followed for other activities performed by ABC Company.

Company Background

ABC Company helps organizations work with investors and manage equity. We assist with managing cap tables, valuations, liquidity events, cap table sharing, board approvals, and shareholder updates.The company is headquartered in San Francisco, CA and has raised $150 million from top investment firms.

Overview of the Service

The ABC Company Platform was developed by ABC Company. Its functionalities are maintained through various modules and is the system of record for the services that ABC Company provides. The Company's technology platform is hosted on cloud computing infrastructure that can be accessed from any web browser through abccompany.com.

This text provides a general understanding of ABC Company's technology stack. The rest of the section provides short descriptions of:

- Auditor's responsibilities
- Management's responsibilities
- Audit limitations
- Auditor's opinion

The auditor's opinion is the part that most people flip to when they first receive their report. This is where the auditor shares the results of the audit.

This report reveals that ABC Company's controls "operated effectively" throughout the period of the audit. This means the company passed the audit and is SOC 2 compliant. Despite the positive outcome, the auditors may still have found opportunities for improvement. Details on that information are further down in the report.

Section II: Management assertion

In this section, ABC Company management gives its own system description. This confirms that they are on the same page with their auditing firm.

Management also asserts that its security controls are “suitably designed” and “operated effectively.”

Section III: System description

Previous sections provide a summary of the system, but this section goes into much greater detail.

The system description includes the personnel involved, along with their roles and responsibilities. Finally, system components and controls are grouped with their respective Common Criteria.

Section IV: Tests of controls

Although this is by far the longest section of the report, it’s the easiest to read. It outlines the general auditing procedure and shows individual tests in a table format.

Trust Services Category, Criteria, Related Controls, Test of Controls and Results of Tests Criteria Related to the Security (Common Criteria) Category					
Criteria	*Trust Services Criteria*	*Control Number*	*Controls Specified by ABC Company*	*Tests of Controls Performed by Auditor Firm*	*Results of Tests*
	Common Criteria Related to Control Environment				
CC1.1	The entity demonstrates a commitment to integrity and ethical values.	1.1a	ABC Company Human Resourcesand Information Technolog y teams review and update the organizational structure, reporting lines, and responsibilities on a quarterly basis.	Interviewed ABC Company personnel and confirmed the control procedure described. Inspected Organizational Chart and determined that the structure, reporting lines, and responsibilities are documented. Inspected quarterly review meeting minutes and found that meeting minutes document Humans Resources and Information Technology teams review and update the organizational structure and responsibilities.	No exceptions noted.
		1.1b	ABC Company has a formal Information Security Policy that addresses internal and external security issues relevant to the Platform and its users. The Policy establishes roles, responsibilities, and rules for achieving ABC Company's information security goals. All new hires are required to read and accept this Policy during onboarding.	Interviewed ABC Company personnel and confirmed the control procedure described. Reviewed the Information Security Policy and confirmed that ABC Company has established a formal Policy. Examined the onboarding process for a selection of new hires to determine whether they received and accepted the Policy during onboarding.	Exception noted. For 1 of 45 new hires selected, Policy acknowledgement was not documented. For another 2 of 45 new hires selected, acknowledgements were dated several months after the hire date.

This test reviews ABC Company's internal controls under the Control Environment (CC1) criteria. The auditor checks whether the company “demonstrates a commitment to integrity and ethical values” (Trust Services Criteria) by reviewing controls related to information security policies.

Specifically, the auditor asked ABC Company personnel whether security policies are reviewed (1.1a) or acknowledged by new hires (1.1b). The auditor noted that 1 in 45 new hires didn't acknowledge the policies. 2 in 45 new hires only reviewed them long after accepting the job.

Section V: Other information

While many SOC 2 reports end at this point, some reports provide management responses to exceptions noted in the tests. Here ABC Company acknowledges that some new hires didn’t review security policies and commits to checking more frequently.

Management's Responses to Exceptions Noted

Criteria Number	Criteria Details	Controls Specified by ABC Company	Results of Tests Performed	Management Response
1.1	The entity demonstrates a commitment to integrity and ethical values.	ABC Company has a formal Information Security Policy that addresses internal and external security Issues relevant to the Platform and its users. The Policy establishes roles. responsibilities, and rules for achieving ABC Company's information security goals. All new hires are required to read and accept this Policy during onboarding	Exception noted. For 1 of 45 new hires selected, Policy acknowledgement was not documented. For another 2 of 45 new hires selected, acknowledgements were dated several months after the hire date.	ABC Company will perform more frequent reviews of policy acknowledgements for new hires in the future.
1.3	Management establishes, with board oversight, structures, reporting lines, and appropriate authorities and responsibilities in the pursuit of objectives.			
1.4	The entity demonstrates a commitment to attract, develop, and retain competent individuals in alignment with objectives.			
5.3	The entity deploys control activities through policies that establish what is expected and in procedures that put policies into action.			

Illustrative SOC 2 Report Example

Download this illustrative example of a complete SOC 2 Type II Report for a more in-depth look at what a report might cover and how long it may be.

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SOC 2 Report Validity

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- Why is SOC 2 Important?
- SOC 1 vs SOC 2 vs SOC 3
- Trust Services Criteria
- SOC 2 Common Criteria
- SOC 2 Controls List: What Controls Do You Need to Implement?
- The History of SOC 2

Report Structures

- What is a SOC 2 Report?
- What Does a SOC 2 Report Cover?
- A Real-World SOC 2 Report Example Explained [+ Free PDF Download]

- SOC 2 Report Validity
- Common SOC 2 Audit Exceptions and How to Avoid Them
- What is a SOC 2 Bridge Letter? + Template

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- SOC 2 Type 1 vs Type 2
- The SOC 2 Audit Process
- How Long Does a SOC 2 Audit Take?
- How Much Does a SOC 2 Audit Cost?
- Who Performs a SOC 2 Audit?
- SOC 2 Audit Frequency

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